Threat Intelligence Brief: Scattered Spider

TLP:CLEAR (open-source reporting) | **Date:** October 21, 2026 | **Prepared by:** OKUNNUWA JOSHUA GODWIN

Aliases: UNC3944, Octo Tempest, Storm-0875, 0ktapus, Muddled Libra | **MITRE ATT&CK:** G1015 | **Motivation:** Financial (data theft, extortion, ransomware)

Bottom Line

Scattered Spider doesn't need much malware. They call the IT help desk, pose as an employee, and get a password and MFA reset. After that they log in like anyone else and use legitimate admin tools, which is why they are so hard to catch. Since 2023 this has worked on casinos, retailers, insurers, airlines and transit. Several core members are now in custody or have pleaded guilty. I don't expect that to end the problem, because anyone can copy the method.

Actor Profile

Scattered Spider is a loose group of mostly young, native English speakers. It came out of a cybercrime community called The Com and has been active since at least 2022. CISA and the FBI say they go after large companies and the IT help desks those companies contract out to (AA23-320A). They also pass access to ransomware partners, including BlackCat/ALPHV in 2023 and DragonForce in 2025. A DOJ indictment alleges more than 100 victims and at least $115 millions in ransoms. Since 2025 they have teamed up with ShinyHunters and Lapsus$ under the name "Scattered Lapsus$ Hunters."

Key Incidents

Date	Victim	Detail
Sept 2023	MGM Resorts, Caesars	Help desk social engineering, outages, data theft
Aug 2024	Transport for London	Disruptive intrusion; two members pleaded guilty in June 2026
Apr 2025	Marks & Spencer	Help desk impersonation, ransomware handoff
Sept 2025	Jaguar Land Rover	Attributed to the merged collective; production halted for weeks

How They Operate

1. **Getting in:** They call help desks, send SMS links to fake login pages, swap SIMS, spam MFA prompts, and steal session tokens.
2. **Staying in:** They create new accounts, enroll their own MFA devices, and install legitimate remote tools like Atera.
3. **Hiding:** They switch off security tools. They have even joined incident response calls to listen in on defenders.
4. **Getting paid:** They stage data and send it to cloud storage. When they want to encrypt, they run ransomware on VMware ESXi hosts.

Tools reported: Atera, Raccoon Stealer, Spectre RAT, ransomware from partners.

MITRE ATT&CK Mapping

Source: MITRE G1015 and CISA AA23-320A (ATT&CK v17).

Tactic	Technique	Observed behavior
Reconnaissance	T1598.004 Spearphishing Voice	Calling help desks for account details

Tactic	Technique	Observed behavior
Resource Development	T1583.001 Domains	Lookalike corporate login portals
Initial Access	T1566.002 Spearphishing Link	Phishing kits, fake SSO pages
Initial Access	T1451 SIM Card Swap	Taking over numbers to catch MFA codes
Initial Access	T1078 Valid Accounts	Stolen or reset credentials
Credential Access	T1621 MFA Request Generation	Repeated push prompts
Credential Access	T1539 Steal Web Session Cookie	Token theft to skip MFA
Persistence	T1136 Create Account	New identities in the victim network
Persistence	T1556.006 Modify Auth Process: MFA	Enrolling attacker MFA devices
Defense Evasion	T1562.001 Disable or Modify Tools	Removing security software
Defense Evasion	T1656 Impersonation	Posing as staff and IT
Command and Control	T1219 Remote Access Software	Legitimate tools as backdoors
Exfiltration	T1567.002 Exfiltration to Cloud Storage	Data moved to cloud services
Impact	T1486 Data Encrypted for Impact	BlackCat/ALPHV, DragonForce

Status and Confidence

Tyler Buchanan pleaded guilty in the US (April 2026), and Thalha Jubair and Owen Flowers pleaded guilty in the UK (June 2026). ShinyHunters is still breaching large companies. I'm confident about the TTPs because government and vendor sources agree. I'm less sure who is in the group today, since membership shifts and what they claim on Telegram can't be trusted.

Detection and Defense

- Alert on a password or MFA reset followed by a new device enrollment within hours.
- Flag new remote access tools, security agent removal, and bulk cloud downloads.
- Require phishing-resistant MFA (FIDO2) for staff and admins.
- Verify help desk callers by call-back to a known number or manager approval, with no exceptions.
- Allow-list remote tools, keep offline backups of ESXi hosts, and plan out-of-band incident communications.

Sources

1. CISA/FBI, AA23-320A Scattered Spider (updated July 2025): https://www.cisa.gov/news-events/cybersecurity-advisories/aa23-320a
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5. DarkOwl, Scattered Lapsus$ Hunters (Jan 2026): https://www.darkowl.com/blog-content/threat-actor-spotlight-scattered-lapsus-hunters/